PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Toyota Land Cruiser 80 Series

1990–1997 · FJ80 · FZJ80 · HZJ80 · HDJ80

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Pull the knuckle fill plug**
  Slee's inspection list says to look for oil and caked grease on the outside of the front knuckles, a sign the inner axle seals failed a long time ago. Remove the square fill plug and sample the grease: if it's runny, diff oil is getting into the knuckle.
- [ ] **Look for coolant at the head**
  Check the head-to-block joint for antifreeze weeping, ask whether the radiator has been replaced (a possible sign of past overheating), and look for deposits in the overflow bottle. Head gaskets are on every 80 buyer's list of common problems.
- [ ] **Rust in the footwells and rear windows**
  Get under it and check the front footwells on both sides and the body around the rear windows, which buyers' guides single out (owners report the same), especially on trucks from salted-road states. Also check under the battery tray for corrosion, which Slee's list calls out.
- [ ] **Cracks around the steering box**
  The frame around the steering box is a known weak point, more so on trucks that have run 33s or bigger. Look for cracks and ask whether a reinforcement plate has been fitted.
- [ ] **Test the lockers properly**
  If it has factory lockers, engage them in low range on a loose surface and make sure they actually lock. Actuators that won't engage are a common fault, and an actuator rebuild usually fixes them.
- [ ] **Know which year you're looking at**
  1991–92 FJ80s have the 4.0 L 3F-E, a C-clip semi-float rear with drums and no factory lockers. From 1993 you get the 4.5 L 1FZ-FE, optional lockers and a full-float rear with discs on ABS trucks. The automatic type is printed on the driver's-door label: A442F on 1993–94 trucks, A343F on most 1995–97 trucks (some '95s kept the A442F).
- [ ] **Check for accident repairs**
  Late 80s had VIN stickers on almost every body panel, so check they're on the doors, hood and tailgate. Look for overspray, weld marks on the inner fenders and core support, filler (use a magnet) and pulling marks on the frame.
- [ ] **Look behind the dash**
  Built trucks often have a mess of accessory wiring. Pop the panel under the steering column, look for extra leads on the battery positive and check they're fused, and test every light and switch.

YEARS TO KNOW

1993	SWEET SPOT	FZJ80 arrives: 4.5 L 24-valve 1FZ-FE, A442F auto, 16-inch wheels, larger brakes (from October 1992 production); ABS trucks get a full-floating rear axle with discs and the viscous-coupling HF2AV transfer case; factory front and rear lockers (option K294) become optional; center-diff switch dropped (wiring stays); A/C switches from R12 to

R134a in May 1993. This 1993–97 FZJ80 run is the one owners recommend over the 3F-E trucks; the 1995–97 changes are minor by comparison

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- [ ] **Reese Class II trailer hitch (aftermarket equipment)**
  1991–1993 · NHTSA 93E023000

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **FJ80 vs FZJ80**
  1991–92 FJ80s have the 4.0 L 3F-E pushrod six and 15-inch wheels; 1993–97 FZJ80s have the 4.5 L DOHC 1FZ-FE and 16-inch wheels. A center-diff lock switch on the dash is standard on 1991–92 trucks only.
- [ ] **Factory lockers**
  Optional 1993–97 (Toyota option code K294). Locked trucks have a rotary front/rear locker switch on the dash. Test them: engage in low range on a loose surface and make sure the dash lights come on and the axle actually locks.
- [ ] **Transmission and build date**
  The transmission type (A442F on 1993–94, A343F on most 1995–97 trucks) is printed on the label in the driver's door jamb. The A/C changed from R12 to R134a in May 1993, around VIN JT3DJ81xxxxx38947; R12 trucks have the dryer in front of the battery, R134a trucks behind the bumper.
- [ ] **Body-panel VIN stickers**
  Late 80s carry VIN stickers on most body panels. Missing stickers, overspray or filler on a panel point to accident repair.
- [ ] **Special editions and LX 450**
  The 1997 40th Anniversary has a serialized console badge, two-tone leather, black-chrome badges and Antique Sage Pearl or Emerald Green paint. The LX 450 (1996–97) adds body cladding, its own grille and wheels and extra sound insulation on the same FZJ80 running gear.
- [ ] **Chassis codes**
  Market codes add a suffix (for example FZJ80R); R means right-hand drive outside Japan. HDJ80 and HZJ80 diesels were never sold new in the US.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/land-cruiser/80-series/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks